

# 02244 Logic for Security Security Protocols Channels and Composition

Sebastian Mödersheim

March 2, 2026

## Challenge from Previous Module

Consider the following protocol:

$A \rightarrow B: A, NA$

$B \rightarrow s: A, B, NA, NB, \{ | A, NA, NB | \}_{sk(B, s)}$

$s \rightarrow A: \{ | B, KAB, NA, NB | \}_{sk(A, s)}, \{ | A, KAB | \}_{sk(B, s)}$

$A \rightarrow B: \{ | A, KAB | \}_{sk(B, s)}, \{ | NB | \}_{KAB}$

- Can you find a type-flaw attack against this protocol?  
Hint: ignore  $A$  and  $s$  and consider just one honest  $b$  in role  $B$ .
- Can you suggest formats for this protocol so that it becomes type-flaw resistant?

# Challenge from Previous Module

Consider the following protocol:

$A \rightarrow B: A, NA$

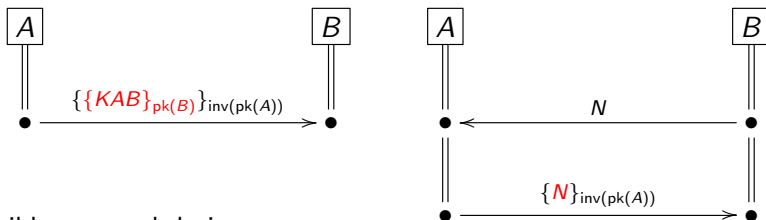
$B \rightarrow s: A, B, NA, NB, \{ | A, NA, NB | \}_{sk(B, s)}$

$s \rightarrow A: \{ | B, KAB, NA, NB | \}_{sk(A, s)}, \{ | A, KAB | \}_{sk(B, s)}$

$A \rightarrow B: \{ | A, KAB | \}_{sk(B, s)}, \{ | NB | \}_{KAB}$

- Can you find a type-flaw attack against this protocol?  
Hint: ignore  $A$  and  $s$  and consider just one honest  $b$  in role  $B$ .
  - ★ You can of course type the spec into OFMC, but let's see if we can find the attack using the hint and the lazy intruder technique.
- Can you suggest formats for this protocol so that it becomes type-flaw resistant?

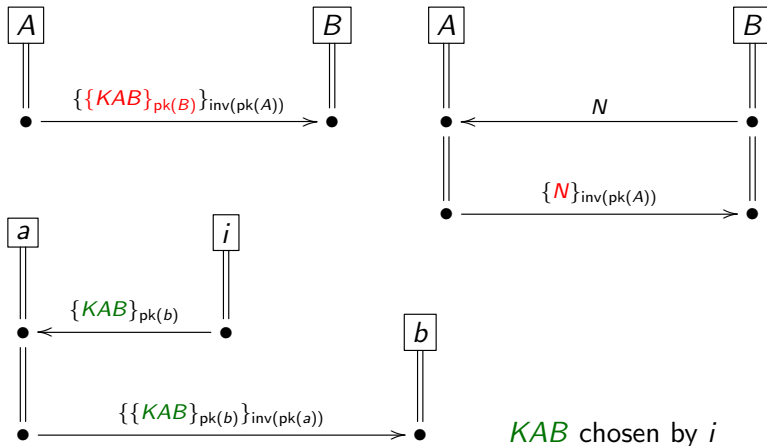
## Recall: Mind the Environment



Terrible protocol design:

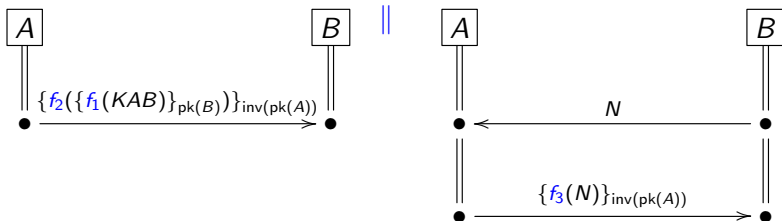
- while each of these protocols is (somewhat) secure in isolation
- together they break because the **signed messages** don't say what they mean...

## Recall: Mind the Environment



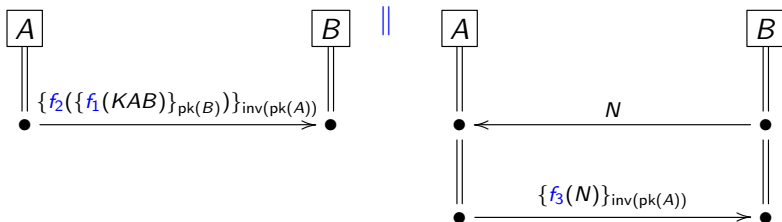
Attack/Confusion:  $a$  runs right protocol,  $b$  runs left protocol.  
This is called a **type flaw attack**.

# Parallel Composition



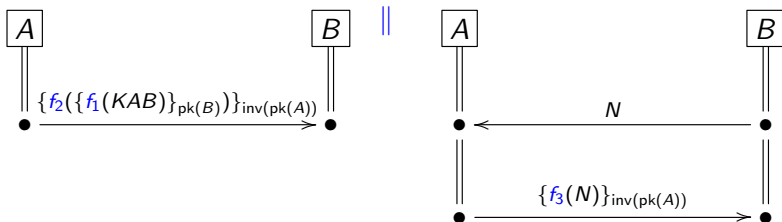
- When the two protocols are **disjoint formats**, the attack is not possible anymore.

# Parallel Composition



- When the two protocols are **disjoint formats**, the attack is not possible anymore.
- Goal: **Parallel Compositionality**
  - ★ Verify: each component protocol is secure in isolation.
  - ★ Ensure some syntactic conditions like **disjoint formats**
  - ★ Then their parallel composition is also secure.

# Parallel Composition



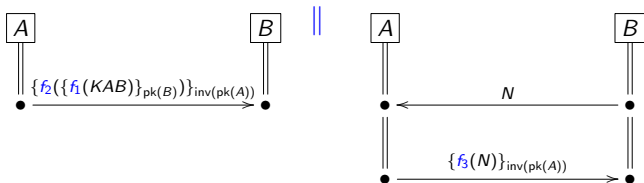
- When the two protocols are **disjoint formats**, the attack is not possible anymore.
- Goal: **Parallel Compositionality**
  - ★ Verify: each component protocol is secure in isolation.
  - ★ Ensure some syntactic conditions like **disjoint formats**
  - ★ Then their parallel composition is also secure.
- Relevant: there are tons of protocols on the Internet
  - ★ Verifying them all at once is too complex
  - ★ Every new addition would require verification to start from zero



# Parallel Composition Result [Hess et al.'18]

## Definition (Parallel Composability)

- Given **type-flaw resistant** protocols  $P_1$  and  $P_2$
- There is a special set of **shared secrets** (e.g.  $\text{inv}(\text{pk}(a))$ ).
- Some of these secrets are **explicitly declassified** (e.g.  $\text{pk}(a), \text{pk}(i), \text{inv}(\text{pk}(i))$ ).
- Every well-typed message part of  $P_1$  and  $P_2$  is
  - ★ either a shared secret (classified or declassified)
  - ★ or **unique** to one of the protocols
- Neither protocol (in isolation) ever leaks a classified secret.



# Parallel Composition Result [Hess et al.'18]

## Theorem (Parallel Composability)

*If  $P_1$  and  $P_2$  are parallel composable and both secure in isolation, then also  $P_1 \parallel P_2$  is secure.*

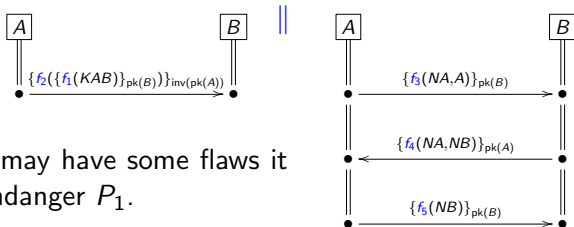
# Parallel Composition Result [Hess et al.'18]

## Theorem (Parallel Composability)

If  $P_1$  and  $P_2$  are parallel composable and both secure in isolation, then also  $P_1 \parallel P_2$  is secure.

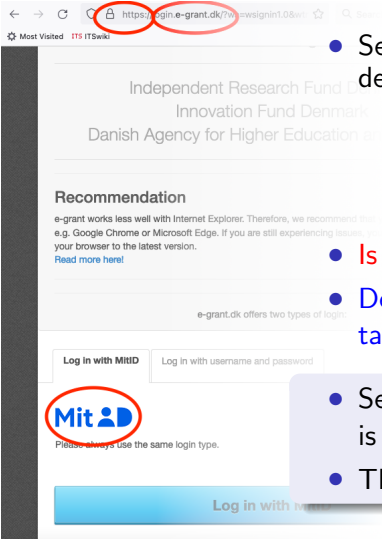
## Theorem (Parallel Composability–Important Variant)

If  $P_1$  and  $P_2$  are parallel composable and  $P_1$  is secure in isolation, then  $P_1 \parallel P_2$  does not break any goals of  $P_1$ .



Even if  $P_2$  may have some flaws it does not endanger  $P_1$ .

# Vertical Composition: Example and Motivation

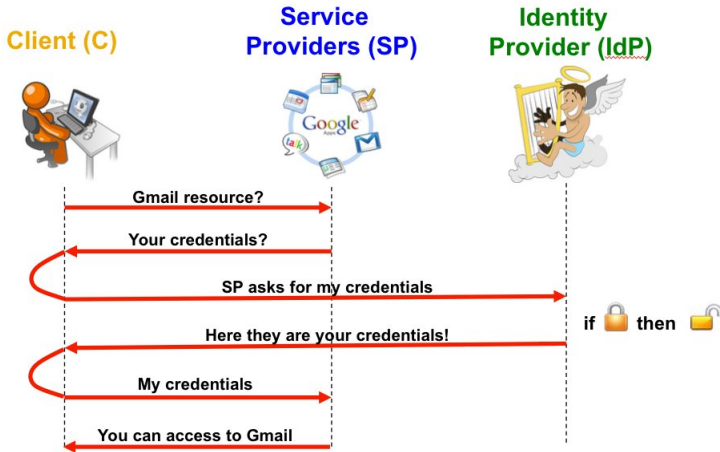


- Several components from independent developers:
  - ★ TLS (https): secure channels, authenticate servers
  - ★ MitID: authenticate user
  - ★ Payload application: e-grant system

- Is this secure?
- Developers cannot—and should not—all talk to each other!

- Security of components like TLS and MitID is well-understood.
- Their composition is not.

# Example: Single Sign-On (SSO) with web-browser



Leaving abstract two components here:

- The channels are running over TLS
- The client must in some way authenticate to the IdP

# Google's SSO

Knowledge: C: C, idp, SP, pk(idp);  
          idp: C, idp, pk(idp), inv(pk(idp));  
          SP: idp, SP, pk(idp)

Actions:

[C]  $\ast \rightarrow \ast$  SP : C, SP, URI  
SP  $\ast \rightarrow \ast$  [C] : C, idp, SP, URI

C  $\ast \rightarrow \ast$  idp : C, idp, SP, URI  
idp  $\ast \rightarrow \ast$  C : {C, idp}inv(pk(idp)), URI

[C]  $\ast \rightarrow \ast$  SP : {C, idp}inv(pk(idp)), URI  
SP  $\ast \rightarrow \ast$  [C] : Data

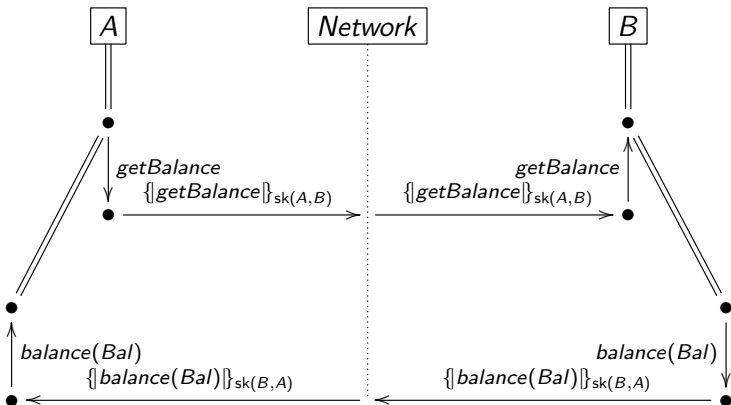
Goals:

SP authenticates C on URI

C authenticates SP on Data

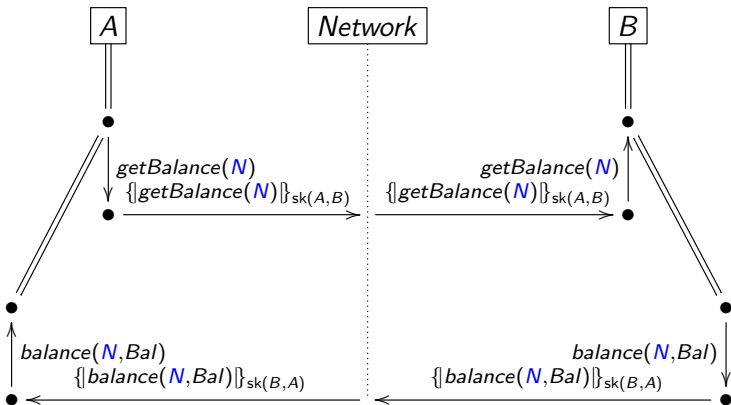
Data secret between SP, C

# Layering



- Simple banking application: A asks for her account balance
- Simple channel: just encrypt with  $sk(A, B)$  or  $sk(B, A)$  (depending on direction)

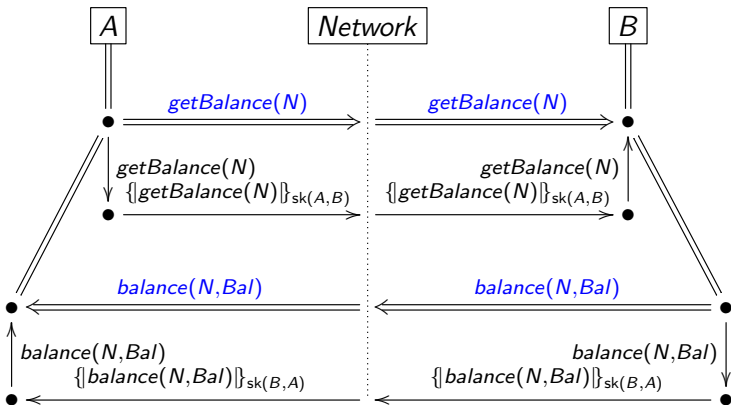
# Layering



Let's protect also against replay! (It is not done by this channel.)



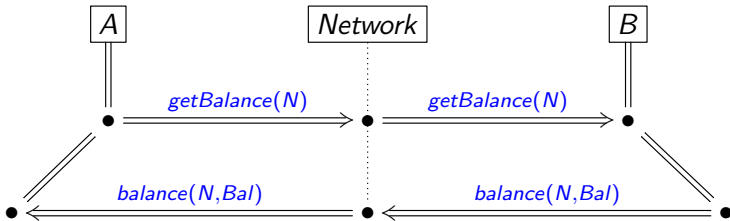
# Layering



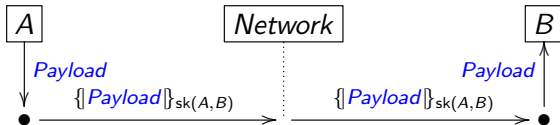
The channel is almost like a **secure line** between A and B.

# Layering

Split between an application:

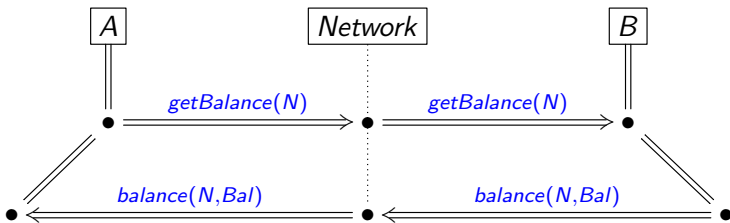


and a channel:

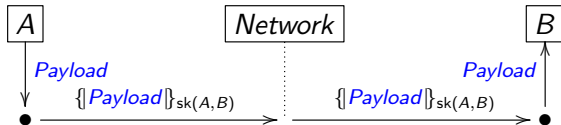


# Layering

Split between an application:



and a channel:



Idea: we can replace the channel with something more complicated (like TLS), but we can verify the application with the simple channel.

# Notation

Notation due to [Maurer and Schmidt]:

- $A \bullet \rightarrow B$  for an **authentic** channel from  $A$  to  $B$ .
  - ★  $B$  can be sure the message comes from  $A$ , but we do not guarantee confidentiality.
- $A \rightarrow \bullet B$  for a **confidential** channel from  $A$  to  $B$ .
  - ★  $A$  can be sure that only  $B$  can read this message, but we do not guarantee authenticity.
- $A \bullet \rightarrow \bullet B$  for a **secure** channel from  $A$  to  $B$ 
  - ★ Both authentic and confidential.

OFMC supports this notation (write ★ for •):

## Example (NSL)

$$\begin{array}{lll} A & \rightarrow & B : \{NA, A\}_{pk(B)} \\ B & \rightarrow & A : \{NA, NB, B\}_{pk(A)} \\ A & \rightarrow & B : \{NB\}_{pk(B)} \end{array}$$

# Notation

Notation due to [Maurer and Schmidt]:

- $A \bullet \rightarrow B$  for an **authentic** channel from  $A$  to  $B$ .
  - ★  $B$  can be sure the message comes from  $A$ , but we do not guarantee confidentiality.
- $A \rightarrow \bullet B$  for a **confidential** channel from  $A$  to  $B$ .
  - ★  $A$  can be sure that only  $B$  can read this message, but we do not guarantee authenticity.
- $A \bullet \rightarrow \bullet B$  for a **secure** channel from  $A$  to  $B$ 
  - ★ Both authentic and confidential.

OFMC supports this notation (write ★ for ●):

## Example (NSL)

$$\begin{array}{lll} A & \rightarrow \bullet & B : NA, A \\ B & \rightarrow \bullet & A : NA, NB, B \\ A & \rightarrow \bullet & B : NB \end{array}$$

- using **confidential channels** instead of crypto.

# Implementing Channels with Cryptography

- Assume every agent  $A$  has two key pairs:
  - ★  $\langle \text{ck}(A), \text{inv}(\text{ck}(A)) \rangle$  for asymmetric encryption.
  - ★  $\langle \text{ak}(A), \text{inv}(\text{ak}(A)) \rangle$  for digital signatures.
- Assume that every agent knows the public keys  $\text{ck}(A)$  and  $\text{ak}(A)$  of every other agent  $A$ .
- Encode channels by encryption and signing:

## Definition

$$\begin{array}{lll} A & \bullet \rightarrow & B : M \text{ for } A \rightarrow B : \{\text{atag}, B, M\}_{\text{inv}(\text{ak}(A))} \\ A & \rightarrow \bullet & B : M \text{ for } A \rightarrow B : \{\text{ctag}, M\}_{\text{ck}(B)} \\ A & \bullet \rightarrow \bullet & B : M \text{ for } A \rightarrow B : \{\{\text{stag}, B, M\}_{\text{inv}(\text{ak}(A))}\}_{\text{ck}(B)} \end{array}$$

- atag, ctag, and stag are tags to distinguish the channel-encodings from other encryptions.

# A Cryptographic Implementation

## Definition

$$\begin{array}{ll} A \bullet \rightarrow B : M & \text{for } A \rightarrow B : \{\text{atag}, B, M\}_{\text{inv}(\text{ak}(A))} \\ A \rightarrow \bullet B : M & \text{for } A \rightarrow B : \{\text{ctag}, M\}_{\text{ck}(B)} \\ A \bullet \rightarrow \bullet B : M & \text{for } A \rightarrow B : \{\{\text{stag}, B, M\}_{\text{inv}(\text{ak}(A))}\}_{\text{ck}(B)} \end{array}$$

- This ensures the basic properties of channels:
  - ★ Only  $A$  can produce messages on the channel  $A \bullet \rightarrow B$ .
  - ★ Only  $B$  can read messages on the channel  $A \rightarrow \bullet B$ .
  - ★ Both restrictions on a secure channel.
- Note that the intruder can still intercept and replay messages!
- This model of channels can be used with all models and tools without extensions!

# Authenticated Recipient

## Definition

$$\begin{array}{ll} A \bullet \rightarrow B : M \text{ for } A \rightarrow B : \{\text{atag}, B, M\}_{\text{inv}(\text{ak}(A))} \\ A \rightarrow \bullet B : M \text{ for } A \rightarrow B : \{\text{ctag}, M\}_{\text{ck}(B)} \\ A \bullet \rightarrow \bullet B : M \text{ for } A \rightarrow B : \{\{\text{stag}, B, M\}_{\text{inv}(\text{ak}(A))}\}_{\text{ck}(B)} \end{array}$$

Why is the recipient  $B$  contained in the signatures?

- Including the name  $B$  means to **authenticate the intended recipient**.



# Channel Calculus

## Channel Calculus Rule

- If we have an authentic channel  $A \bullet \rightarrow B$
- Then we can achieve a confidential channel  $B \rightarrow \bullet A$  in the opposite direction

# Channel Calculus

## Channel Calculus Rule

- If we have a confidential channel  $A \rightarrow \bullet B$
- Then we can achieve an authentic channel  $B \bullet \rightarrow A$  in the opposite direction

# Channel Calculus

## Channel Calculus Rule

- If we have a secure channel  $A \bullet \rightarrow \bullet B$
- Then we can achieve a secure channel  $B \bullet \rightarrow \bullet A$  in the opposite direction.

## Channel Calculus Rule

- If we have an authenticated channel  $A \bullet \rightarrow B$
- and a confidential channel  $A \rightarrow \bullet B$ .
- Then we can achieve a secure channel  $A \bullet \rightarrow \bullet B$ .
- **Challenge:** Try to prove these two rules yourself.
- It is also obvious we can “downgrade” from secure to authentic or to confidential.
- This is all we can achieve without further assumptions.
- **Challenge:** Let  $s$  be an **honest** server. Suppose we have channels  $s \bullet \rightarrow \bullet A$  and  $s \bullet \rightarrow \bullet B$ , can we achieve  $A \bullet \rightarrow \bullet B$ ? Why does  $s$  have to be honest for that?

# TLS handshake (simplified)

$A \rightarrow B : A, B, \exp(g, X), \text{cert}_A$

$B \rightarrow A : \exp(g, Y),$

let  $k1 = \text{clientK}(\exp(\exp(g, X), Y))$

let  $k2 = \text{serverK}(\exp(\exp(g, X), Y))$

$\{\{\text{cert}_B\}\}_{k_2},$

$\{\{h(\text{all previous messages})\}_{\text{inv}(\text{pk}(B))}\}_{k_2}$

$A \rightarrow B \quad \{\{h(\text{all previous messages})\}_{\text{inv}(\text{pk}(A))}\}_{k_1}$

$\text{cert}_A = \{A, \text{pk}(A), \dots\}_{\text{inv}(\text{pk}(s))}$  is a public key certificate, and  $h$ ,  $\text{clientK}$ ,  $\text{serverK}$  are hash/key-derivation functions.

Consider also the transmission of a payload with the created keys:

$A \rightarrow B : \{\{data, \text{DATA}_A\}\}_{k_1}$

$B \rightarrow A : \{\{data, \text{DATA}_B\}\}_{k_2}$

---

Goal :  $A \bullet \rightarrow \bullet B : \text{DATA}_A$

$B \bullet \rightarrow \bullet A : \text{DATA}_B$

# Recall: Channel Calculus

## Channel Calculus Rule

- If we have a confidential channel  $A \rightarrow \bullet B$
- Then we can achieve an authentic channel  $B \bullet \rightarrow A$  in the opposite direction

$A \rightarrow \bullet B : K$

$B \rightarrow A : \{\{ \text{Payload} \} \}_K$

- Actually this is also a pseudonymous channel!
- Notation suggested by [M. & Viganò] and supported by OFMC:

$$B \bullet \rightarrow \bullet [A] \text{ and } [A] \bullet \rightarrow \bullet B$$

$A$  and  $B$  have a secure channel except  $B$  can't be sure who  $A$  is.

- TLS without client authentication establishes this channel.
- Login using TLS is then:  $[A] \bullet \rightarrow \bullet B : \text{login}, A, \text{password}(A, B)$
- Which finally achieves  $A \bullet \rightarrow \bullet B$

# Cryptographic Model of Secure Pseudonymous Channels

OFMC implements pseudonymous channels as follows:

## Definition

$$\begin{array}{ll}
 [A : P] & \bullet \rightarrow \quad B : \quad M \text{ for } A \rightarrow B : \{ \text{atag}, B, M \}_{\text{inv}(P)} \\
 A & \rightarrow \bullet \quad [B : P] : \quad M \text{ for } A \rightarrow B : \{ \text{ctag}, M \}_P \\
 [A : P] & \bullet \rightarrow \bullet \quad B : \quad M \text{ for } A \rightarrow B : \{ \{ \text{stag}, B, M \}_{\text{inv}(P)} \}_{\text{ck}(B)} \\
 A & \bullet \rightarrow \bullet \quad [B : P] : \quad M \text{ for } A \rightarrow B : \{ \{ \text{stag}, P, M \}_{\text{inv}(\text{ak}(A))} \}_P
 \end{array}$$

where we explicitly annotate the pseudonym/public-key  $P$  being used. By default, we have a fresh public-key  $P$  for every protocol session and agent.

# Vertical Composition Result

Sébastien Gondron and Sebastian Mödersheim. *Vertical Composition and Sound Payload Abstraction for Stateful Protocols*. CSF 2021:

- Definition of **channel protocols**
  - ★ This entails an **ideal functionality** similar to  $A \rightarrow \bullet B$ .
  - ★ Uses an abstract notion of **payload** messages
- Definition of **application protocols**
- Application and Channel interact with each other through buffers  $inbox(A, B)$  and  $outbox(A, B)$  that contain **payload** messages.
- Requirements on their message formats:
  - ★ No overlap, and requirements of parallel composability
- The application is secure with the ideal functionality of the channel.
- The channel indeed implements the ideal functionality with all abstract payloads that are
  - ★ are either known or unknown to the intruder
  - ★ are either novel or a repetition
- Then also the vertical composition is secure.

# Challenges

As a little exercises

- Consider the **challenges** of the channel calculus.
- Consider the banking example of page 17 (actual pdf-pagenumber).
  - ★ Extend the banking application by a transfer message where  $A$  can specify an amount of money and a recipient  $C$ .
  - ★ Protect the transfer against replay (without changing the channel).
  - ★ How could one implement a channel that has replay protection built in?
  - ★ Suppose  $A$  later claims she never made the transfer. Can  $B$  prove to an honest third party *judy* (“without reasonable doubt”) that  $A$  indeed *did* make the transfer?



## Relevant Research Papers

- Ueli Maurer, Pierre Schmid: *A Calculus for Security Bootstrapping in Distrib. Systems*. J. of Comp. Sec. 4(1) 1996.
- Joshua Guttman and F. Javier Thayer: *Protocol independence through disjoint encryption*. CSFW 2000.
- Alessandro Armando et al.: *Formal analysis of SAML 2.0 web browser single sign-on*. FMSE 2008.
- Sebastian Mödersheim and Luca Viganò. *Secure Pseudonymous Channels*. ESORICS 2009.
- Véronique Cortier and Stéphanie Delaune. *Safely composing security protocols*. Formal Methods Syst. Des. 34(1), 2009.
- Joshua Guttman: *Cryptographic Protocol Composition via the Authentication Tests*. FOSSACS 2009. *Secure Composition of PKIs with Public Key Protocols*. CSF 2017.
- Andreas Hess, Sebastian Mödersheim and Achim Brucker. *Stateful Protocol Composition*. ESORICS 2018.
- Andreas Hess, Sebastian Mödersheim, and Achim Brucker. *Stateful Protocol Composition in Isabelle/HOL*. In ACM Trans. on Privacy and Security, 2023.
- Jan Camenisch et al.: *iUC: Flexible Universal Composability Made Simple*. ASIACRYPT 2019.
- Sébastien Gondron and Sebastian Mödersheim. *Vertical Composition and Sound Payload Abstraction for Stateful Protocols*. CSF 2021.  
<http://imm.dtu.dk/samo/AbstractPayload.pdf>